Critical Histories of Social Work: An Annotated Bibliography

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Scope and method

This bibliography gathers historical books, peer-reviewed articles, and dissertations that critique US social work, its professional bodies, and the agencies social workers built or staffed. International works appear when they are comparative or directly inform US debates.

- **Inclusion rule:** the work makes a historical argument about how social work caused harm, served social control, excluded groups, or abandoned reform. Works that recover resistance and overlooked contributions are included when they frame that recovery as a corrective to the field's official history.
- **Verification:** every entry was checked against a publisher page, library catalog, journal record, or DOI, and each carries the link used. Annotations are paraphrased, not quoted.
- **Organization:** each work sits under its primary critique. Many works span several; cross-listing is noted only where the second theme is central.
- **Limits:** no bibliography of this literature can be truly exhaustive. Items that could not be confirmed are listed separately at the end rather than presented as fact.

1. Professionalization, abandonment of mission, and the retreat from reform

The core claim here: the pursuit of professional status pulled social work away from poor people and structural reform toward casework, therapy, and occupational self-interest. *Unfaithful Angels* is the best-known statement; Lubove is the foundational history.

Books

- Specht, H., & Courtney, M. E. (1994). *Unfaithful angels: How social work has abandoned its mission*. Free Press. catalog
  Argues the profession traded work with the poor and communities for private psychotherapy with middle-class clients.

- Lubove, R. (1965). *The professional altruist: The emergence of social work as a career, 1880-1930*. Harvard University Press. catalog
  Shows casework technique and the drive for professional standing displacing voluntarism and reform.
- Ehrenreich, J. H. (1985). *The altruistic imagination: A history of social work and social policy in the United States*. Cornell University Press. publisher
  Traces the swing between reform and psychological casework and how the profession's class position constrained its politics.
- Wenocur, S., & Reisch, M. (1989). *From charity to enterprise: The development of American social work in a market economy*. University of Illinois Press. catalog
  Reads professionalization as a market strategy to secure an occupational monopoly at the cost of reform goals. (Paperback reissue 2001.)
- Walkowitz, D. J. (1999). *Working with class: Social workers and the politics of middle-class identity*. University of North Carolina Press. listing
  Examines how social workers built a middle-class professional identity that separated them from clients and from their own labor position.
- Lowe, G. R., & Reid, P. N. (Eds.). (1999). *The professionalization of poverty: Social work and the poor in the twentieth century*. Aldine de Gruyter. catalog
  Edited volume testing whether professionalization turned the field away from serving the poor.
- Trolander, J. A. (1987). *Professionalism and social change: From the settlement house movement to neighborhood centers, 1886 to the present*. Columbia University Press. catalog
  Shows professionalization converting settlements into neighborhood centers with weaker reform and community roots.
- Wagner, D. (1990). *The quest for a radical profession: Social service careers and political ideology*. University Press of America. catalog
  Follows radical social workers over their careers and documents how organizational and professional pressures eroded their politics.
- Fisher, J. (1980). *The response of social work to the Depression*. G. K. Hall. catalog
  Examines the profession's Depression-era response, including the rank-and-file challenge to its mainstream.

Articles

- Austin, D. M. (1983). The Flexner myth and the history of social work. *Social Service Review, 57*(3), 357-377. https://doi.org/10.1086/644113
  Argues that fixation on Flexner's 1915 judgment produced a narrow, status-driven idea

of professionhood.

- Haynes, K. S. (1998). The one hundred-year debate: Social reform versus individual treatment. *Social Work, 43*(6), 501-509. https://doi.org/10.1093/sw/43.6.501
  Traces the casework versus reform tension and the dominance of individual treatment.
- Abramovitz, M. (1998). Social work and social reform: An arena of struggle. *Social Work, 43*(6), 512-526. https://doi.org/10.1093/sw/43.6.512
  Shows the activist strand repeatedly pushed aside by conservative, individual-focused practice.
- Cloward, R. A., & Piven, F. F. (1977). The acquiescence of social work. *Society, 14*(2), 55-63. https://doi.org/10.1007/BF02695151
  Charges that social work helped administer punitive treatment of welfare recipients rather than defending them.

2. Social control and the regulation of the poor

These works argue that charity, relief, and casework functioned to classify, discipline, and manage poor people, often under the language of help.

Books

- Piven, F. F., & Cloward, R. A. (1971). *Regulating the poor: The functions of public welfare*. Pantheon Books. catalog
  Argues relief expands to calm civil disorder and contracts to enforce low-wage work.
- Katz, M. B. (1986). *In the shadow of the poorhouse: A social history of welfare in America*. Basic Books. catalog
  Critiques scientific charity and casework as tools for sorting, deterring, and disciplining the poor.
- Margolin, L. (1997). *Under the cover of kindness: The invention of social work*. University Press of Virginia. publisher
  Foucauldian reading of helping practices as surveillance and power over clients.
- Polsky, A. J. (1991). *The rise of the therapeutic state*. Princeton University Press. catalog
  Shows helping professionals, including social workers, building a state apparatus that normalizes marginal families through therapeutic intervention.
- Rothman, D. J. (1980). *Conscience and convenience: The asylum and its alternatives in progressive America*. Little, Brown. catalog
  Shows probation, parole, and juvenile courts expanding discretionary control over poor and deviant people under a benevolent frame.

- Crocker, R. H. (1992). *Social work and social order: The settlement movement in two industrial cities, 1889-1930*. University of Illinois Press. catalog
  Recasts Indiana settlements as agents of order and Americanization in working-class and immigrant neighborhoods.
- Wagner, D. (2000). *What's love got to do with it? A critical look at American charity*. New Press. catalog
  Argues charity and the nonprofit sector often serve donor interest and social control rather than redistribution.
- Soss, J., Fording, R. C., & Schram, S. F. (2011). *Disciplining the poor: Neoliberal paternalism and the persistent power of race*. University of Chicago Press. record
  Analyzes post-1996 welfare as racialized discipline delivered through frontline case management.

Articles

- Gettleman, M. E. (1963). Charity and social classes in the United States, 1874-1900, I. *American Journal of Economics and Sociology, 22*(2), 314-329. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1536-7150.1963.tb00888.x
  Reads Gilded Age scientific charity as an expression of elite class interest and anxiety about the working poor.

3. Race, racism, and Black social workers and communities

Two strands sit together here: critiques of segregation and white control within social work, and recovery histories that treat the erasure of Black social welfare traditions, including mutual aid and self-help, as a critique of the field's official story.

Racism, segregation, and white control of the profession

- Bell, J. M. (2014). *The Black Power movement and American social work*. Columbia University Press. publisher
  Black social workers in the late 1960s challenging white control of professional bodies, through reform and through separate institutions.
- Lasch-Quinn, E. (1993). *Black neighbors: Race and the limits of reform in the American settlement house movement, 1890-1945*. University of North Carolina Press. publisher
  Mainstream settlements ignoring, segregating, or leaving as Black residents arrived.
- Philpott, T. L. (1978). *The slum and the ghetto: Neighborhood deterioration and middle-class reform, Chicago, 1880-1930*. Oxford University Press. catalog
  Reformers, including settlement workers, aiding immigrants while accepting and

helping build the Black ghetto.

- Gordon, L. (1991). Black and white visions of welfare: Women's welfare activism, 1890-1945. *Journal of American History, 78*(2), 559-590. https://doi.org/10.2307/2079534
  How race and class shaped white reformers' welfare ideas in contrast to Black activists'. End page confirmed only from a secondary source.
- Gary, R. B., & Gary, L. E. (1994). The history of social work education for Black people 1900-1930. *Journal of Sociology and Social Welfare, 21*(1). https://doi.org/10.15453/0191-5096.2109
  Exclusion from mainstream schools and the separate programs Black institutions built.
- Platt, T., & Chandler, S. (1988). Constant struggle: E. Franklin Frazier and Black social work in the 1920s. *Social Work, 33*(4), 293-297. https://doi.org/10.1093/sw/33.4.293
  Frazier at the Atlanta School of Social Work, confronting white paternalism and Jim Crow.
- Ward, G. K. (2012). *The Black child-savers: Racial democracy and juvenile justice*. University of Chicago Press. record
  Jim Crow in juvenile courts and reform schools and Black reformers' campaign against it.
- Abrams, L. S., & Moio, J. A. (2009). Critical race theory and the cultural competence dilemma in social work education. *Journal of Social Work Education, 45*(2), 245-261. https://doi.org/10.5175/JSWE.2009.200700109
  Cultural competence skirting structural racism. Not historical, but widely cited in this literature.
- Wright, K. C., Carr, K. A., & Akin, B. A. (2021). The whitewashing of social work history: How dismantling racism in social work education begins with an equitable history of the profession. *Advances in Social Work, 21*(2/3), 274-297. https://doi.org/10.18060/23946
  The white-founder origin story erasing Black contributions and sustaining curricular racism.
- Abrams, L. S., Crewe, S. E., Dettlaff, A. J., & Williams, J. H. (Eds.). (2023). *Social work, white supremacy, and racial justice: Reckoning with our history, interrogating our present, reimagining our future*. Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780197641422.001.0001
  White supremacy across the profession's history, institutions, and practice.
- Dettlaff, A. J. (2023). *Confronting the racist legacy of the American child welfare system: The case for abolition*. Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780197675267.001.0001

Child welfare rooted in anti-Black racism; argues for abolition. See also Billingsley and Giovannoni (1972) in section 5.

- National Association of Social Workers. (2021, June 17). *NASW apologizes for racist practices in American social work* [Press release]. release
  Institutional acknowledgment of support for segregated settlements, eugenics, and recruitment for the Tuskegee study. A primary source, not scholarship.

Black social welfare traditions, mutual aid, and recovered histories

- Ross, E. L. (Ed.). (1978). *Black heritage in social welfare, 1860-1930*. Scarecrow Press. catalog
  Documentary collection restoring Black social welfare thought omitted from standard histories. Editor role very likely but not shown on the catalog record.
- Carlton-LaNey, I. B. (Ed.). (2001). *African American leadership: An empowerment tradition in social welfare history*. NASW Press. publisher
  Black leaders and empowerment practice as a corrective to white-centered history.
- Carlton-LaNey, I., & Burwell, N. Y. (Eds.). (1996). *African American community practice models: Historical and contemporary responses*. Haworth Press. record
  Community-building and mutual aid models developed despite exclusion. Also issued as *Journal of Community Practice, 2*(4).
- Carlton-LaNey, I. (1999). African American social work pioneers' response to need. *Social Work, 44*(4), 311-321. https://doi.org/10.1093/sw/44.4.311
  Values and methods of Progressive Era Black social workers left out of mainstream histories.
- Carlton-LaNey, I. (1994). The career of Birdye Henrietta Haynes, a pioneer settlement house worker. *Social Service Review, 68*(2), 254-273. https://doi.org/10.1086/604050
- Peebles-Wilkins, W. (1989). Black women and American social welfare: The life of Fredericka Douglass Sprague Perry. *Affilia, 4*(1), 33-44. https://doi.org/10.1177/088610998900400104
  Black self-help filling gaps white agencies left in segregated Kansas City.
- Peebles-Wilkins, W., & Francis, E. A. (1990). Two outstanding Black women in social welfare history: Mary Church Terrell and Ida B. Wells-Barnett. *Affilia, 5*(4), 87-100. https://doi.org/10.1177/088610999000500406
- Hounmenou, C. (2012). Black settlement houses and oppositional consciousness. *Journal of Black Studies, 43*(6), 646-666. https://doi.org/10.1177/0021934712441203
  Black settlements as resistance to white settlement exclusion.

- Gilkes, C. T. (1983). Going up for the oppressed: The career mobility of Black women community workers. *Journal of Social Issues, 39*(3), 115-139. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-4560.1983.tb00159.x
  Careers defined by community service rather than individual professional advancement.
- Shaw, S. J. (1996). *What a woman ought to be and to do: Black professional women workers during the Jim Crow era*. University of Chicago Press. record
- Reed, T. F. (2008). *Not alms but opportunity: The Urban League and the politics of racial uplift, 1910-1950*. University of North Carolina Press. https://doi.org/10.5149/9780807888544_reed
  Critical look at the Urban League's class assumptions and the limits of uplift social work.
- Reid-Merritt, P. (2010). *Righteous self determination: The Black social work movement in America*. Inprint Editions. catalog
  The founding of NABSW as a response to racism inside mainstream social work.
- Carten, A. J. (2020). *Find a way or make one: A documentary history of Clark Atlanta University Whitney M. Young Jr. School of Social Work (1920-2020)*. Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780197518465.001.0001
  The Atlanta school's race-conscious training tradition, built in response to exclusion.

4. Gender, motherhood, sexuality, and the regulation of families

These histories show caseworkers and maternalist reformers enforcing class, race, and gender norms on poor women, and building professional authority through that work. A short subgroup on fathers follows, since no book-length history of social work's treatment of fathers could be found.

Books

- Gordon, L. (1988). *Heroes of their own lives: The politics and history of family violence: Boston, 1880-1960*. Viking. record
  Uses child protection case records to show caseworkers imposing class and gender norms while clients bargained with agencies.
- Gordon, L. (1994). *Pitied but not entitled: Single mothers and the history of welfare, 1890-1935*. Free Press. record
  Argues women reformers and social workers built a stigmatized, means-tested track for single mothers apart from social insurance.

- Abramovitz, M. (1988). *Regulating the lives of women: Social welfare policy from colonial times to the present*. South End Press. record
  Traces a family ethic in welfare policy that rewards approved wife and mother roles and punishes others.
- Kunzel, R. G. (1993). *Fallen women, problem girls: Unmarried mothers and the professionalization of social work, 1890-1945*. Yale University Press. record
  Shows social workers displacing evangelical women in maternity homes by diagnosing unmarried mothers as cases.
- Tice, K. W. (1998). *Tales of wayward girls and immoral women: Case records and the professionalization of social work*. University of Illinois Press. record
  Reads case records as moral narratives that served the profession's claims to expertise.
- Odem, M. E. (1995). *Delinquent daughters: Protecting and policing adolescent female sexuality in the United States, 1885-1920*. University of North Carolina Press. record
  Shows reformers, courts, and agencies policing working-class girls' sexuality as protection.
- Muncy, R. (1991). *Creating a female dominion in American reform, 1890-1935*. Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780195057027.001.0001
  Examines the women's professional sphere in child welfare and how its hierarchy limited policy.
- Ladd-Taylor, M. (1994). *Mother-work: Women, child welfare, and the state, 1890-1930*. University of Illinois Press. record
  Shows middle-class motherhood ideals becoming standards imposed on poor mothers.
- Ladd-Taylor, M., & Umansky, L. (Eds.). (1998). *"Bad" mothers: The politics of blame in twentieth-century America*. New York University Press. record
  Essays on how experts and agencies labeled mothers deficient and blamed them for social problems.
- Mink, G. (1995). *The wages of motherhood: Inequality in the welfare state, 1917-1942*. Cornell University Press. https://doi.org/10.7591/9781501728860
  Argues maternalist policy tied aid to cultural conformity, especially for immigrant mothers and mothers of color.
- Stadum, B. (1992). *Poor women and their families: Hard working charity cases, 1900-1930*. State University of New York Press. record
  Contrasts poor women's survival strategies with caseworkers' judgments, using Minneapolis records.

- Solinger, R. (1992). *Wake up little Susie: Single pregnancy and race before Roe v. Wade*. Routledge. record
  Shows social workers treating white and Black unwed mothers differently, including pressure on white mothers to relinquish.
- Jones, K. W. (1999). *Taming the troublesome child: American families, child guidance, and the limits of psychiatric authority*. Harvard University Press. https://doi.org/10.4159/9780674039216
  Examines how child guidance, including psychiatric social workers, framed children's problems and often blamed mothers.
- Mittelstadt, J. (2005). *From welfare to workfare: The unintended consequences of liberal reform, 1945-1965*. University of North Carolina Press. https://doi.org/10.5149/uncp/9780807855874
  Shows postwar social workers' rehabilitation agenda for ADC mothers laying ground for work requirements.
- Nadasen, P. (2004 or 2005). *Welfare warriors: The welfare rights movement in the United States*. Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203819500
  Black welfare recipients organizing against degrading agency treatment. Year differs across records; check the copyright page.
- Kornbluh, F. (2007). *The battle for welfare rights: Politics and poverty in modern America*. University of Pennsylvania Press. record
  Recipients challenging caseworkers' arbitrary and moralizing power in the 1960s.
- Gustafson, K. S. (2011). *Cheating welfare: Public assistance and the criminalization of poverty*. New York University Press. https://doi.org/10.18574/nyu/9780814732311.001.0001
  Shows welfare administration treating recipients as suspected criminals.

Articles

- Curran, L. (2002). The psychology of poverty: Professional social work and Aid to Dependent Children in postwar America, 1946-1963. *Social Service Review, 76*(3), 365-386. https://doi.org/10.1086/341180
  Critiques psychological framing that turned ADC mothers' poverty into personal maladjustment.

Fathers and men in welfare history

- Igra, A. R. (2007). *Wives without husbands: Marriage, desertion, and welfare in New York, 1900-1935*. University of North Carolina Press. record
  Charity and welfare agencies pursuing deserting husbands to enforce private family

support.

- Lefkovitz, A. (2011). Men in the house: Race, welfare, and the regulation of men's sexuality in the United States, 1961-1972. *Journal of the History of Sexuality, 20*(3), 594-614. https://doi.org/10.1353/sex.2011.0057
  Analyzes "man in the house" rules that pushed men, especially Black men, out of welfare households.
- Willrich, M. (2000). Home slackers: Men, the state, and welfare in modern America. *Journal of American History, 87*(2), 460-489. repository
  Recovers court-centered policing of nonsupporting men alongside mothers' pensions; courts more than social work.

5. Child welfare, child saving, and family policing

This literature argues that child saving, foster care, and adoption served to control poor and racialized families, and that modern child protection substitutes surveillance for material support. Indigenous child removal is covered in section 6.

Historical books

- Platt, A. M. (1969). *The child savers: The invention of delinquency*. University of Chicago Press. record
  Revisionist classic: middle-class child savers built the juvenile court to control lower-class youth.
- Billingsley, A., & Giovannoni, J. M. (1972). *Children of the storm: Black children and American child welfare*. Harcourt Brace Jovanovich. record
  Early critique of the racist exclusion and underservice of Black children in child welfare. Also central to section 3.
- Holt, M. I. (1992). *The orphan trains: Placing out in America*. University of Nebraska Press. record
  Examines the child-saving assumptions behind moving poor urban children to rural families.
- Tanenhaus, D. S. (2004). *Juvenile justice in the making*. Oxford University Press. record
  Shows Chicago's juvenile court, probation, and family supervision developing piecemeal and short of reformers' claims.
- Herman, E. (2008). *Kinship by design: A history of adoption in the modern United States*. University of Chicago Press.
  https://doi.org/10.7208/chicago/9780226328072.001.0001

Social workers and other experts trying to engineer kinship through matching and regulation.

- Chávez-García, M. (2012). *States of delinquency: Race and science in the making of California's juvenile justice system*. University of California Press. https://doi.org/10.1525/california/9780520271715.001.0001
  Eugenic science and caseworker assessment targeting youth of color in reform schools.
- Rymph, C. E. (2017). *Raising government children: A history of foster care and the American welfare state*. University of North Carolina Press. https://doi.org/10.5149/northcarolina/9781469635644.001.0001
  Foster care becoming a means-tested system tied to punitive public assistance policy.
- Raz, M. (2020). *Abusive policies: How the American child welfare system lost its way*. University of North Carolina Press. https://doi.org/10.5149/northcarolina/9781469661216.001.0001
  Mandatory reporting and abuse-centered policy since the 1970s expanding surveillance of poor families and families of color.
- Briggs, L. (2012). *Somebody's children: The politics of transracial and transnational adoption*. Duke University Press. publisher
  Adoption across race and borders depending on removal from poor and marginalized mothers; includes the making of ICWA.
- Briggs, L. (2020). *Taking children: A history of American terror*. University of California Press. https://doi.org/10.1525/9780520975071
  Family separation as a recurring US state practice against enslaved, Native, Black, immigrant, and poor families.
- Bernstein, N. (2001). *The lost children of Wilder: The epic struggle to change foster care*. Pantheon Books. record
  The Wilder litigation exposing religious and racial inequity in New York City's agency foster care.

Critical policy analyses with historical arguments

- Pelton, L. H. (1989). *For reasons of poverty: A critical analysis of the public child welfare system in the United States*. Praeger. record
  Argues the system punishes poverty through removal instead of material aid.
- Lindsey, D. (1994). *The welfare of children*. Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780195085181.001.0001
  Argues child welfare became an investigation system rather than an antipoverty one.

- Roberts, D. (2002). *Shattered bonds: The color of child welfare*. Basic Civitas Books. record
  Disproportionate separation and policing of Black families. Some records show a December 2001 release.
- Roberts, D. (2022). *Torn apart: How the child welfare system destroys Black families, and how abolition can build a safer world*. Basic Books. record
  Recasts child welfare as family policing linked to the carceral state and argues for abolition.
- Fong, K. (2023). *Investigating families: Motherhood in the shadow of Child Protective Services*. Princeton University Press. https://doi.org/10.1515/9780691235738
  Contemporary sociology, not history: the reporting system subjecting poor mothers to routine surveillance.

6. Settler colonialism, immigrants, Americanization, and Japanese American incarceration

These works document social work's direct role in Indigenous child removal, the incarceration of Japanese Americans, and assimilationist campaigns aimed at immigrants. Yoosun Park's body of work is the most sustained US scholarship on professional complicity.

Indigenous child removal and settler colonialism

- Jacobs, M. D. (2009). *White mother to a dark race: Settler colonialism, maternalism, and the removal of indigenous children in the American West and Australia, 1880-1940*. University of Nebraska Press. catalog
  White women reformers using maternalism to justify removal in the US and Australia. Comparative.
- Jacobs, M. D. (2014). *A generation removed: The fostering and adoption of Indigenous children in the postwar world*. University of Nebraska Press. catalog
  Postwar agencies and professionals placing Native children in non-Native homes across the US, Canada, and Australia. Comparative.
- Jacobs, M. D. (2013). Remembering the "forgotten child": The American Indian child welfare crisis of the 1960s and 1970s. *American Indian Quarterly, 37*(1-2), 136-159. https://doi.org/10.5250/amerindiquar.37.1-2.0136
  Mass removal of Native children by child welfare authorities before ICWA.

- Thibeault, D., & Spencer, M. S. (2019). The Indian Adoption Project and the profession of social work. *Social Service Review, 93*(4), 804-832. https://doi.org/10.1086/706771
  The BIA and CWLA project's harm to Native communities and a call for social work education to reckon with it.
- Fortier, C., & Hon-Sing Wong, E. (2019). The settler colonialism of social work and the social work of settler colonialism. *Settler Colonial Studies, 9*(4), 437-456. https://doi.org/10.1080/2201473X.2018.1519962
  Argues the profession is built into and serves settler colonialism. Mainly Canadian.

Japanese American incarceration

- Park, Y. (2019). *Facilitating injustice: The complicity of social workers in the forced removal and incarceration of Japanese Americans, 1941-1946*. Oxford University Press. record
  Social workers and their organizations helping carry out removal and incarceration.
- Park, Y. (2008). Facilitating injustice: Tracing the role of social workers in the World War II internment of Japanese Americans. *Social Service Review, 82*(3), 447-483. https://doi.org/10.1086/592361
  The article that first set out this argument.
- Park, Y. (2013). The role of the YWCA in the World War II internment of Japanese Americans: A cautionary tale for social work. *Social Service Review, 87*(3), 477-524. https://doi.org/10.1086/671987
  A welfare organization's camp work smoothing the operation of incarceration.

Immigrants, Americanization, and Latinx communities

- Park, Y., & Reisch, M. (2022). To "elevate, humanize, Christianize, Americanize": Social work, white supremacy, and the Americanization movement, 1880-1930. *Social Service Review, 96*(4), 779-835. https://doi.org/10.1086/722095
  Roots social work's Americanization work in white supremacist ideas of belonging.
- Park, Y., & Kemp, S. P. (2006). "Little alien colonies": Representations of immigrants and their neighborhoods in social work discourse, 1875-1924. *Social Service Review, 80*(4), 705-734. https://doi.org/10.1086/507934
  Early social work writing casting immigrant neighborhoods as foreign and disordered.
- Park, Y. (2006). Constructing immigrants: A historical discourse analysis of the representations of immigrants in U.S. social work, 1882-1952. *Journal of Social Work, 6*(2), 169-203. https://doi.org/10.1177/1468017306066673
  Seven decades of racialized, deficit-based portrayals. Confirmed via the author's faculty page; check the DOI.

- Lissak, R. S. (1989). *Pluralism and progressives: Hull House and the new immigrants, 1890-1919*. University of Chicago Press. publisher
  Hull House pressing immigrants toward assimilation rather than pluralism.
- Carson, M. (1990). *Settlement folk: Social thought and the American settlement movement, 1885-1930*. University of Chicago Press. catalog
  Intellectual history that is critical in places of settlement paternalism.
- Fitzgerald, M. (2006). *Habits of compassion: Irish Catholic nuns and the origins of New York's welfare system, 1830-1920*. University of Illinois Press. publisher
  Critiques Protestant charity reformers' punitive aid by contrast with nuns' work among poor immigrants.
- Balderrama, F. E., & Rodríguez, R. (2006). *Decade of betrayal: Mexican repatriation in the 1930s* (Rev. ed.). University of New Mexico Press. catalog
  Mass expulsion of Mexicans and Mexican Americans in which relief agencies took part.
- Briggs, L. (2002). *Reproducing empire: Race, sex, science, and U.S. imperialism in Puerto Rico*. University of California Press. catalog
  Reformers and experts managing Puerto Rican women's fertility, including sterilization. Also fits section 7.

7. Eugenics and coercive reproductive control

These works show social workers and welfare systems labeling, institutionalizing, and sterilizing poor women and people deemed unfit. Briggs (2002) in section 6 also belongs here.

Articles

- Kennedy, A. C. (2008). Eugenics, "degenerate girls," and social workers during the Progressive Era. *Affilia, 23*(1), 22-37. https://doi.org/10.1177/0886109907310473
  Progressive Era social workers using eugenic ideas to label and control young women judged sexually delinquent.
- Yingling, M. E. (2016). "The Mother State and her weaker children": Social work and the institutionalization of the "feebleminded." *Affilia, 31*(4), 504-519. https://doi.org/10.1177/0886109915604896
  Social workers using maternalist politics to justify institutionalizing people labeled feebleminded.
- Lawrence, J. (2000). The Indian Health Service and the sterilization of Native American women. *American Indian Quarterly, 24*(3), 400-419. https://doi.org/10.1353/aiq.2000.0008

Coercive sterilization by a federal health agency in the 1970s. Context rather than a social work critique.

Books

- Ladd-Taylor, M. (2017). *Fixing the poor: Eugenic sterilization and child welfare in the twentieth century*. Johns Hopkins University Press. catalog
  Sterilization in Minnesota running through ordinary county welfare and child welfare systems.
- Schoen, J. (2005). *Choice and coercion: Birth control, sterilization, and abortion in public health and welfare*. University of North Carolina Press. catalog
  North Carolina's welfare and eugenics programs both widening and restricting poor women's choices.
- Stern, A. M. (2005). *Eugenic nation: Faults and frontiers of better breeding in modern America*. University of California Press. record
  Western eugenics, including California sterilization targeting Mexican Americans.
- Kline, W. (2001). *Building a better race: Gender, sexuality, and eugenics from the turn of the century to the baby boom*. University of California Press. catalog
  Eugenics shaping ideas of women's sexuality and the sterilization of women labeled feebleminded.

8. Radical traditions, political repression, and the carceral turn

These works recover the radical strand the profession sidelined, document Cold War purges, and trace social work's ties to policing and criminalization.

Radical traditions and anticommunist repression

- Reisch, M., & Andrews, J. (2001). *The road not taken: A history of radical social work in the United States*. Brunner-Routledge. catalog
  How the mainstream sidelined and suppressed the radical tradition, especially under Cold War pressure.
- Reynolds, B. C. (1963). *An uncharted journey: Fifty years of growth in social work*. Citadel Press. catalog
  Primary-source memoir of a left practitioner on the profession's retreat from labor and her own blacklisting.
- Andrews, J., & Reisch, M. (1997). The legacy of McCarthyism on social group work: An historical analysis. *Journal of Sociology & Social Welfare, 24*(3). https://doi.org/10.15453/0191-5096.2445

Anticommunist purges stripping reform from group work.

- Reisch, M., & Andrews, J. (1999). Uncovering a silent betrayal: Using oral history to explore the impact of McCarthyism on the profession of social work in the United States. *The Oral History Review, 26*(2), 87-106. https://doi.org/10.1093/ohr/26.2.87
  The profession's failure to defend colleagues targeted by red-baiting.

See also Fisher (1980) and Wagner (1990) in section 1.

Policing and the carceral turn

- Roberts, A. R. (1976). Police social workers: A history. *Social Work, 21*(4), 294-299. https://doi.org/10.1093/sw/21.4.294
  Mostly descriptive history of social workers inside police departments; useful as an origin point.
- Appier, J. (1998). *Policing women: The sexual politics of law enforcement and the LAPD*. Temple University Press. publisher
  Early policewomen using a social work model helped build more aggressive policing.
- Kim, M. E. (2020). The carceral creep: Gender-based violence, race, and the expansion of the punitive state, 1973-1983. *Social Problems, 67*(2), 251-269. https://doi.org/10.1093/socpro/spz013
  The anti-violence movement, social services included, feeding punitive state growth.
- Kim, M. E. (2013). Challenging the pursuit of criminalisation in an era of mass incarceration: The limitations of social work responses to domestic violence in the USA. *British Journal of Social Work, 43*(7), 1276-1293. https://doi.org/10.1093/bjsw/bcs060
  Social work's reliance on criminal legal responses to domestic violence.
- Jacobs, L. A., Kim, M. E., Whitfield, D. L., Gartner, R. E., Panichelli, M., Kattari, S. K., Downey, M. M., McQueen, S. S., & Mountz, S. E. (2021). Defund the police: Moving towards an anti-carceral social work. *Journal of Progressive Human Services, 32*(1), 37-62. https://doi.org/10.1080/10428232.2020.1852865
  Historical and present complicity with policing and a case for anti-carceral practice.
- Richie, B. E., & Martensen, K. M. (2020). Resisting carcerality, embracing abolition: Implications for feminist social work practice. *Affilia, 35*(1), 12-16. https://doi.org/10.1177/0886109919897576
  Feminist social work's carceral ties and an abolitionist alternative.

See also Roberts (2022) in section 5.

9. International and comparative critical histories

The book you had in mind is almost certainly Ioakimidis and Wyllie's *Social Work's Histories of Complicity and Resistance* (2023); its title uses "complicity," not "complexity." It is the strongest comparative anchor, with chapters spanning 13 countries including the US.

Global and comparative

- Ioakimidis, V., & Wyllie, A. (Eds.). (2023). *Social work's histories of complicity and resistance: A tale of two professions*. Policy Press. https://doi.org/10.51952/9781447364306
  Social work serving oppressive and colonial regimes, alongside its resistance traditions. US, Canada, Australia, New Zealand, South Africa, Germany, Spain, Portugal, Southern Cone, Palestine, England, Cyprus, Ireland.
- Ferguson, I., Ioakimidis, V., & Lavalette, M. (2018). *Global social work in a political context: Radical perspectives*. Policy Press. publisher
  The care versus control tension and neoliberal entanglement across countries.
- Midgley, J. (1981). *Professional imperialism: Social work in the Third World*. Heinemann. catalog
  The uncritical export of US and UK models to the global South.
- Gray, M., Coates, J., & Yellow Bird, M. (Eds.). (2008). *Indigenous social work around the world: Towards culturally relevant education and practice*. Ashgate. catalog
  Professional imperialism and the case for Indigenous-grounded practice. Editor status not shown on the record.
- Gray, M., Coates, J., Yellow Bird, M., & Hetherington, T. (Eds.). (2013). *Decolonizing social work*. Ashgate. catalog
  Colonial assumptions in mainstream social work across several continents.

Canada

- Chapman, C., & Withers, A. J. (2019). *A violent history of benevolence: Interlocking oppression in the moral economies of social working*. University of Toronto Press. publisher
  Helping professions in colonial, racial, and disability-based violence presented as benevolence.
- Jennissen, T., & Lundy, C. (2011). *One hundred years of social work: A history of the profession in English Canada, 1900-2000*. Wilfrid Laurier University Press. publisher
  The status versus social action tension, including Cold War pressures; a useful parallel

to US histories.

- Fournier, S., & Crey, E. (1997). *Stolen from our embrace: The abduction of First Nations children and the restoration of Aboriginal communities*. Douglas & McIntyre. catalog
  Residential schools and child welfare apprehension as colonial removal. Publisher now lists 1998.
- Sinclair, R. (2007). Identity lost and found: Lessons from the sixties scoop. *First Peoples Child & Family Review, 3*(1), 65-82. https://doi.org/10.7202/1069527ar
  Mass removal and transracial adoption of Indigenous children.

Australia

- Human Rights and Equal Opportunity Commission. (1997). *Bringing them home: Report of the national inquiry into the separation of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander children from their families*. report
  Official inquiry into the Stolen Generations, in which welfare authorities took part. Pairs with Jacobs (2009, 2014) in section 6.

United Kingdom

- Bailey, R., & Brake, M. (Eds.). (1975). *Radical social work*. Edward Arnold; Pantheon. catalog
  Casework as social control within capitalist welfare. US edition published the same year.
- Corrigan, P., & Leonard, P. (1978). *Social work practice under capitalism: A Marxist approach*. Macmillan. catalog
  State social work reproducing capitalist social relations.
- Jones, C. (1983). *State social work and the working class*. Macmillan. catalog
  Education and the state shaping social work to regulate working-class clients.

Europe and Nazi Germany

- Lorenz, W. (1994). *Social work in a changing Europe*. Routledge. record
  Links between European social work, nationalism, exclusion, and fascist welfare.
- Kunstreich, T. (2003). Social welfare in Nazi Germany: Selection and exclusion. *Journal of Progressive Human Services, 14*(2), 23-52. https://doi.org/10.1300/J059v14n02_02
  Nazi welfare sorting clients into worthy and excluded.
- Barney, D. D., & Dalton, L. E. (2006). Social work under Nazism: An analysis of the "profession-in-the-environment." *Journal of Progressive Human Services, 17*(2), 43-62. https://doi.org/10.1300/J059v17n02_04

How the profession adapted to and carried out Nazi policy, with lessons drawn for US practice.

- Johnson, S., & Moorhead, B. (2011). Social eugenics practices with children in Hitler's Nazi Germany and the role of social work: Lessons for current practice. *Journal of Social Work Values and Ethics, 8*(1). PDF
  Social workers' role in eugenic identification and removal of children.
- Kuhlmann, C. (2023). Social services in Nazi Germany and the role of social workers between complicity and rare resistance. In V. Ioakimidis & A. Wyllie (Eds.), *Social work's histories of complicity and resistance* (pp. 97-108). Policy Press. https://doi.org/10.51952/9781447364306.ch006

South Africa

- Harms-Smith, L., & Turton, Y. (2023). Colonial and apartheid South Africa: Social work complicity and resistance. In V. Ioakimidis & A. Wyllie (Eds.), *Social work's histories of complicity and resistance* (pp. 73-94). Policy Press. https://doi.org/10.51952/9781447364306.ch005
  The profession's role in segregation under colonialism and apartheid.
- Sewpaul, V. (2013). Neoliberalism and social work in South Africa. *Critical and Radical Social Work, 1*(1), 15-30. https://doi.org/10.1332/204986013X665947
  Post-apartheid social work bent to neoliberal agendas that preserve inequality.

10. Dissertations

Seventeen dissertations were confirmed. Entries marked *(AHA db)* come from the American Historical Association's History Dissertation Database, served from a development address; confirm them in ProQuest or WorldCat before citing.

Became major books

- Lasch-Quinn, E. D. (1990). *Black neighbors: Race and the limits of reform in the American settlement movement, 1890-1945* [Doctoral dissertation]. record *(AHA db; institution not confirmed)*
- Kunzel, R. G. (1990). *The professionalization of benevolence: Evangelicals, social workers, and unmarried mothers, 1890 to 1945* [Doctoral dissertation, Yale University]. record *(AHA db)*
- Crocker, R. C. H. (1982). *Sympathy and science: The settlement movement in Gary and Indianapolis, to 1930* [Doctoral dissertation, Purdue University]. repository

- Stadum, B. A. (1987). *"Maybe they will appreciate what I done and struggled": Poor women and their families, charity cases in Minneapolis, 1900-30* [Doctoral dissertation, University of Minnesota]. record *(AHA db; check subtitle punctuation)*
- Kornbluh, F. A. (2000). *A right to welfare? Poor women, professionals, and poverty programs, 1935-75* [Doctoral dissertation, Princeton University]. record *(AHA db)*
- Nadasen, P. (1999). *The welfare rights movement in the United States, 1960-75* [Doctoral dissertation, Columbia University]. record *(AHA db)*

Professionalization, radicalism, and gender

- Hunter, R. W. (1999). *Voices of our past: The rank and file movement in social work, 1931-1950* [Doctoral dissertation, Portland State University]. repository
  The radical union movement and its decline as the profession retreated from structural reform.
- Shoemaker, L. M. (2001). *Charity and justice: Gender and the mission of social work, social work education in Boston, New York, and Chicago, 1898-1930* [Doctoral dissertation, Binghamton University]. record *(AHA db)*

Race, child welfare, and Black women's welfare work

- Simmons, M. C. (2021). *Racialized pathways of protection: The politics of family preservation and child protection in New York City foster care, 1920s-1960s* [Doctoral dissertation, University of California, Berkeley]. PDF
  Family preservation reserved for white families while Black and Puerto Rican children went to segregated foster care.
- Wages, S. (2023). *Remembering, relating, and recording the legacy of Black women social welfare providers* [Doctoral dissertation, University of Wisconsin-Madison]. ProQuest
  Academic social work's erasure of Black women's welfare work. Degree type not shown in the preview.
- Gregory, J. R. (2023). *An exploration of whiteness in social work* [Doctoral dissertation, University of California, Berkeley]. PDF
  Mainly a contemporary study with one historical chapter on white supremacy at the profession's origins.
- Balcom, K. A. (2001). *The traffic in babies* [Doctoral dissertation, Rutgers University]. record *(AHA db; subtitle not confirmed)*
  Comparative US and Canada study of adoption regulation and cross-border baby selling.

Indigenous child removal (US and comparative)

- Blanchard, E. L. (2010). *To prevent the breakup of the Indian family: The development of the Indian Child Welfare Act of 1978* [Doctoral dissertation, University of New Mexico]. repository
- de Bourbon, S. (2013). *Indigenous genocidal tracings: Slavery, transracial adoption, and the Indian Child Welfare Act* [Doctoral dissertation, University of California, Santa Cruz]. PDF
- Stevenson, A. (2015). *Intimate integration: A study of Aboriginal transracial adoption in Saskatchewan, 1944-1984* [Doctoral dissertation, University of Saskatchewan]. record
  Canada, with comparison to the US Indian Adoption Project.
- Timpson, J. B. (1993). *Four decades of child welfare services to native Indians in Ontario: A contemporary attempt to understand the "sixties scoop" in historical, socioeconomic and political perspective* [Doctoral dissertation, Wilfrid Laurier University]. repository

Cold War (comparative)

- Lewey, L. L. (2006). *Nothing to fear but fear: Social work in Cold War Canada, 1945-1960* [Doctoral dissertation, University of Calgary]. repository
  Red-baiting of left Canadian social workers, compared with the US McCarthy era.

11. Not verified, excluded, and gaps

These items were left out of the main list or need a check before citing.

Not verified

- Cloward, R. A., & Epstein, I. Private social welfare's disengagement from the poor: The case of family adjustment agencies. Often cited as 1965; the one confirmable citation places it in Brager & Purcell (Eds.), *Community action against poverty* (College and University Press, 1967), pp. 40-63, but the chapter and pages come only from a secondary source.
- Park, Y., & Reisch, M. *Social work, the Americanization movement, and the construction of Americans, 1874-1930* (Routledge). One retailer lists a June 2026 date; not confirmed with the publisher.
- Sánchez, G. J. "Go after the women": Americanization and the Mexican immigrant woman, 1915-1929. Publication details not confirmed.
- Molina, N. *Fit to be citizens?* (2006). Not checked.
- Gilkes, C. T. *If it wasn't for the women*. Year and publisher not checked.

- Burwell, N. Y. (1994). Article on North Carolina Public Welfare Institutes for Negroes, 1926-1946, *Journal of Sociology and Social Welfare*, DOI 10.15453/0191-5096.2108. Flagged but not fully checked.
- Dissertations behind books by Joyce M. Bell (PhD, University of Minnesota), Yoosun Park (PhD, University of Washington), Tice, Odem, Walkowitz, and Reed: no dissertation record found.

Excluded as background rather than critique

- Kendall, K. A. (2000). *Social work education: Its origins in Europe*. CSWE.
- Healy, L. M. (2001). *International social work: Professional action in an interdependent world*. Oxford University Press.

Gaps worth a targeted search

- No book-length history of how social work treated fathers was found; section 4 lists the closest work.
- No dissertations found on the founding of NABSW, on social work and eugenics, or on social workers and McCarthyism.
- Eugenics histories in *Journal of Sociology & Social Welfare* and NASW publications were not specifically searched.